

Lincoln elected

Although Lincoln won a majority of the electoral votes with 180, he carried less than 40 percent of the national popular vote and 54 percent of the Northern popular vote. Douglas won only New Jersey and Missouri, while Kentucky, Tennessee, and Virginia selected John Bell. Breckinridge carried the remaining Southern states, most of which barred Lincoln's name from appearing on the ballot. Lincoln won, but he faced a nation in which one region had given him almost no support. He would be vulnerable in four years and many believed he would be forced to form a cautious, conservative government.

Although the states of Virginia, Kentucky, and Tennessee rejected the Democratic and Republican candidates, they recognized the risk they faced as states of the Upper South bordering free states. Living along the northern boundary of a slave republic, enslaved people would be tempted by the freedom that lay across the border. Also, if it came to war, it was the Upper South that would become the likely battlefield.

In the majority of these slave states, many wealthy enslavers hoped to preserve the Union. They believed slavery was safer protected by federal law than within an independent slave state bordering free territory. Many of these states had also developed more mixed economies and were less dependent on cotton exports. They had broad connections to their Northern neighbors, but feared they would face hostility from the Deep South.